

02. Federalism

NOTES –

Federalism is a system of government in which the power is divided between central authority and various constituent units of the country. Usually, federation has two levels of government. One is the government for the entire country that is usually responsible for few common subjects in the nation's interest whereas other government at the level of states that look after day-to-day administering of the state.

Features of Federation –

- Two or more levels (tiers) of government.
- Different tiers of government govern the same citizens but has its own jurisdiction. In specific matters of legislation, taxation and administration.
- Jurisdiction of the respective levels of government are specified in the Constitution of India.
- Fundamental provision of the constitution cannot be unilaterally changed by one of the governments.
- Courts have the power to interpret the constitution and powers of different levels of government.
- Sources of revenue for each level government are clearly specified to ensure its financial autonomy.
- An ideal federal system, has both aspects i.e. mutual trust and agreement to live together by safeguarding and promoting unity of the country in diversity.

Question and Answers -

1. What is federalism? Why has federalism succeeded in India?

Federalism is a system of government in which powers are divided between the Central Government and the State Governments by the Constitution.

Reasons for the success of federalism in India:

- Constitutional division of powers between the Union and States.
- Creation of linguistic states to respect regional identities.
- Respect for the Constitution and democratic institutions.
- Decentralisation through Panchayati Raj and Municipalities.
- A spirit of cooperation between different levels of government.

2. Explain the political division of power by giving examples from India.

Political power in India is divided among different levels of government.

- Union Government looks after national matters like defence, foreign affairs, and currency.
- State Governments manage police, agriculture, and public health.

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- Local Governments (Panchayats and Municipalities) deal with local development, sanitation, and water supply.

This division ensures efficient administration and better governance.

3. What is decentralisation? Write only two reasons why decentralisation is favoured in democracy.

Decentralisation means transferring powers from the Central and State Governments to local governments.

Two reasons:

- Local people understand their problems better and can solve them efficiently.
- It increases people's participation in decision-making and strengthens democracy.

4. Differentiate between Holding Together Federation and Coming Together Federation.

Holding Together Federation	Coming Together Federation
Formed by dividing powers between Centre and States.	Formed when independent states unite to form a federation.
Central Government is generally more powerful.	States enjoy equal powers.
Example: India, Spain, Belgium	Example: USA, Switzerland, Australia

5. Explain any five features of federalism.

- Two or more levels of government.
- Division of powers through the Constitution.
- Supremacy of the Constitution.
- Independent judiciary to settle disputes.
- Sources of revenue are clearly divided between the Centre and States.

6. Describe the three forms of power sharing among different organs of government in India.

Power is shared among the three organs of government:

- Legislature makes laws.
- Executive implements and administers laws.

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- Judiciary interprets laws and protects the Constitution.

This system ensures that no organ becomes too powerful.

7. How is federal power sharing more effective today than earlier?

- Regional political parties have become stronger.
 - Coalition governments encourage cooperation between the Centre and States.
 - States now have a greater role in national decision-making.
 - The Centre and States work together through cooperative federalism.
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8. What status has been given to the Hindi language by the Constitution of India?

- Hindi in Devanagari script has been declared the Official Language of the Union.
 - English continues to be used for official purposes along with Hindi.
 - Hindi has not been declared the National Language of India.
 - The Constitution recognises 22 Scheduled Languages.
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9. Explain the threefold distribution of legislative powers between the Union Government and the State Government.

The Constitution divides legislative powers into three lists:

1. Union List – Defence, foreign affairs, banking, currency (only Parliament can make laws).
2. State List – Police, agriculture, public order (only State Legislatures can make laws).
3. Concurrent List – Education, forests, marriage (both Parliament and State Legislatures can make laws).

If there is a conflict on the Concurrent List, the Union law prevails.

10. Write any five advantages of local government.

- Better understanding of local needs.
 - Increases people's participation in governance.
 - Ensures quick solution of local problems.
 - Reduces the workload of State and Central Governments.
 - Promotes accountability and transparency.
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11. Throw light on key features of federalism.

The important features are:

- Two or more levels of government.
 - Constitutional division of powers.
 - Supremacy of the Constitution.
 - Independent judiciary.
 - Separate sources of revenue.
 - Constitution cannot be changed unilaterally.
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12. Which five provisions of the Indian Constitution make India a full-fledged federation?

1. Division of powers between Union and States.
 2. Written Constitution.
 3. Supremacy of the Constitution.
 4. Independent Judiciary.
 5. Rigid Constitution requiring approval of both Parliament and States for important amendments.
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13. Describe the Panchayati Raj system.

The Panchayati Raj system is the system of rural local self-government.

It has three levels:

- Gram Panchayat at the village level.
- Panchayat Samiti (Block level).
- Zila Parishad at the district level.

Features:

- Members are directly elected.
 - One-third of seats are reserved for women.
 - Seats are also reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.
 - It promotes people's participation in local governance.
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14. Define:

(i) Unitary Government

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A Unitary Government is a system in which all powers are concentrated in the hands of the Central Government. States function according to the wishes of the Centre.

(ii) Residuary Subjects

Residuary Subjects are matters that are not mentioned in the Union List, State List, or Concurrent List. In India, Parliament has the power to make laws on these subjects. These are like subjects for digitalization, laws on cyber-crime, etc.

15. "Creation of linguistic states was the first and major test for democratic politics in our country." Justify the statement.

- After Independence, many people demanded states based on language.
- The States Reorganisation Act, 1956 created states on linguistic basis.
- This recognised people's cultural and linguistic identities.
- It strengthened national unity instead of dividing the country.
- It proved that democracy can peacefully accommodate diversity.

EXTRAS –

Quasi-federal: It is a system of government that combines features of both federal and unitary system with the central government having more power than the state.

Why is India Quasi-federal?

India is Quasi-federal nation because the distribution of power between centre and state through the constitution but centre shares some extra powers like declaration of emergency, appointment of governor to states and powers to execute residuary subjects.

-THE END-

Sources: NCERT – Political Science Textbook
Ved Prakash Pandey Sir – Economics and Political teacher, BMSSS
ChatGPT – Answers of the questions.